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The Development of Maritime Trade in Asia

International maritime trade in Asia developed in stages. It first became prosperous along the Middle East-to-india route, expanding after Rome established its *Pax Romana* in the first century of the Christian era and corresponding to a diffusion of knowledge among sailors of Greece and the Roman Orient on the use of the monsoon winds for navigation. When Westerners reached India in the first century they found that a regular maritime route connected India to the Malay Peninsula. Malay seamen and Indian and Arab traders routinely made the voyage from India's eastern coast or Sri Lanka to Southeast Asian ports, which provided access to China's rich markets. In the earliest era of maritime trade, ships from Indian ports touched land on the upper western coast of the Malay Peninsula, their trade goods were portaged across the Isthmus of Kra to the Gulf of Thailand, reloaded on ships, and transported along the coast to ports on the western edge of the Mekong Delta, most notably to one identified by archaeologists as Oc-èo in the Funan realm. The Funan state, based on the lower Vietnam coast, dominated trade in this sector of the commercial route until the fifth century. From Funan ports goods were transported to ports in south China.

Traders of the Roman Empire eventually joined the ships on this route, and Western maritime contacts were extended beyond India and Sri Lanka to Sumatra and other commercial centers at the western end of the Java Sea, which in the post-Funan age came to replace the Malay Peninsula and mainland as the locus of international trade in Southeast Asia. The full development of the maritime route by international traders making regular use of the Strait of Malacca and the South China Sea came in the late fourth and early fifth centuries. By the fifth century commercial intercourse between East and West was concentrated in the maritime route.

As a consequence, during the first five centuries of the Christian era international trade in Southeast Asia became well defined, regular, and prosperous as trade relationships were extended to include new members and products. This expansion of trade in turn stimulated significant transitions in Southeast Asian economic and political organization. Once the route was established through the region interaction between Southeast Asian peoples and foreign merchants was inevitable; the peoples of the region were also exposed to foreign cultures and ideas. Initially, the role of Southeast Asia's ports in the international trade was simply to provide facilities for foreign merchants who were passing through on their way to China or India or laying over until the next season's winds allowed a return voyage. Coastal states on the edges of settled hinterlands served as commercial entrepôts, providing suitable accommodations for sailors and traders, food, water, and shelter, and storage facilities and marketplaces, thus facilitating the exchange of Eastern and Western goods.

Soon, however, Southeast Asian merchants began to market their own spices and aromatics as substitutes for foreign commodities and then built upon this substitution to market other indigenous products. Demand for Southeast Asian products was quickly established when spices from Indonesia's eastern archipelago began to flow out of the Java Sea region to international markets in the fourth and fifth centuries. The new marketing opportunities required more formal political and economic relationships between hinterland populations and coastal commercial communities than had hitherto been necessary, however. The international trade thus acted as an impetus to state-building efforts in the region.

THE EXPANSION OF ROMAN TRADE IN THE INDIAN OCEAN

In the seventh century B.C. goods from India were imported into Babylon along two well-traveled commercial routes. [1] The preferred overland route crossed the mountains of Central Asia. By the fourth century B.C., however, Aramaic inscriptions from the Middle East begin to record an active maritime trade along the coast, with goods being carried by sea from India's northwestern coast to Saleucia in Mesopotamia via the Persian Gulf and the Tigris River. Alexander the Great's admiral, Nearchus, after employing local pilots to explore the Indus River and commissioning a fleet of thirty oared galleys, used the same coastal route to transport Alexander's troops from India to Mesopotamia in 321 B.C.

Very early maritime contact between Middle Eastern and Asian ports was characterized by coastal shipping rather than by transocean voyages. There was apparently little knowledge or use of the seasonal monsoon winds until the first century A.D., except by Malay seamen who were sailing between the Indonesian archipelago and Madagascar. Early Middle Eastern literary references speak colorfully of six-month voyages during which "trained birds" were used to guide ships to land; sailors navigated by the stars and by watching the flight of birds. The small-oared galleys that made these voyages tried to stay within sight of land as they hopped from port to port between Mesopotamia and India.

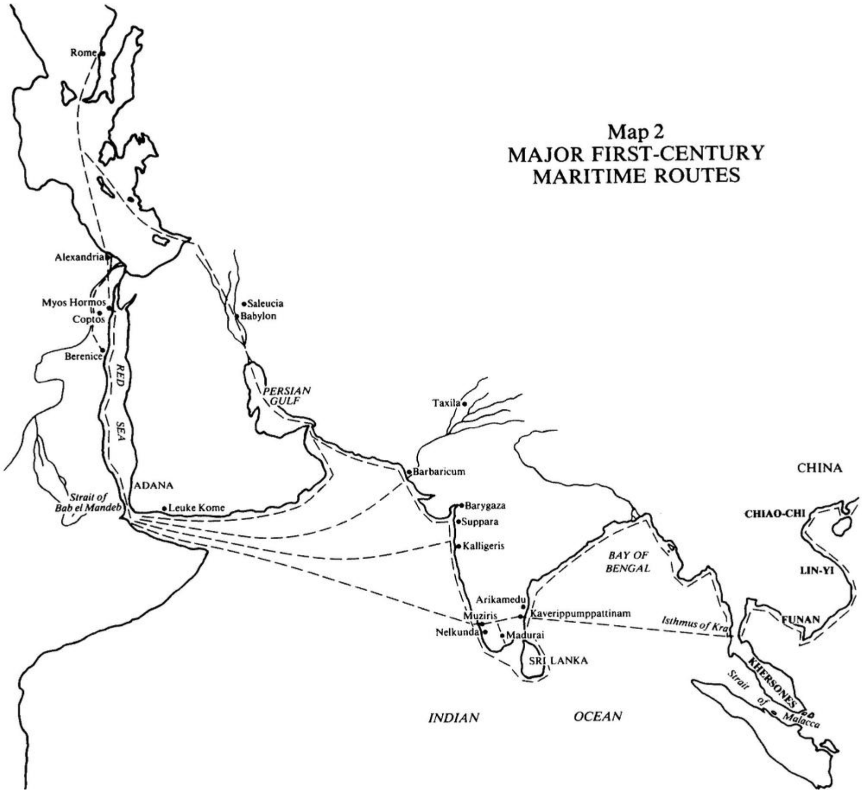
Western markets for goods transported along this coastal route were at first limited because of political fragmentation in the West; the real blossoming of maritime trade between East and West awaited a stable Western market. This peaceful setting was provided after the consolidation of Roman rule. Rome's political growth heralded a demand for luxury goods, among them spices, scented woods, resins, and cloth from the East, which substantially encouraged the expansion of Indian Ocean shipping. Technical advances soon followed as innovations in Western ship construction provided sailing rigs capable of undertaking voyages with larger loads and ultimately promised a means of using the ocean monsoon wind currents, thus enabling navigators to make transoceanic voyages.

The discovery and excavation of the Arikamedu site near Pondicherry on the southeastern coast of India in the late 1940s and early 1950s gave dated proof of the existence of an expanding maritime trade network connecting East and West. [2] Arikamedu was a trade station, an emporium or entrepôt, complete with harbor, warehouses, and merchant residences, which served as a center for the exchange of goods coming from East Asia and the West. Reaching its zenith between A.D. 23–96, Arikamedu was a port of call for convoys of oceangoing merchants during the trading seasons. In the early months of the year merchants would arrive from the West via the northeast monsoon and would depart for home on the southwest monsoon by early summer; seamen would arrive from Southeast Asia shortly thereafter and would leave on the northeast monsoon around the first of the year. Arikamedu was also the permanent residence of the Western merchants known in Indian literature as *yavana.* Archaeological excavations at Arikamedu have shown that its exports to the West included pepper, pearls, gems, muslins, tortoise shell, ivory, and silk. Imports from the West were coral, lead, copper, tin, glass, vases, lamps, wine, and coined money.

Unfortunately, Arikamedu and one or two other south Indian sites stand alone as the major sources of archaeological evidence of this first-century trade. Literary sources are ample, however, particularly those from Rome itself. The earliest of these sources, the *Geography* of Strabo (63 B.C.–A.D. 21), records the growth of the Asian trade, contrasting the smallness of the trade in earlier times to the significant expansion experienced during the reign of the emperor Augustus (27 B.C.–A.D. 14). While formerly only twenty ships passed annually through the Strait of Bab el Mandeb from the Red Sea into the Indian Ocean, now ships were departing for Asia in convoys of 120 from the upper Red Sea port of Myos Hormos alone. [3]

Perhaps the richest of the classical sources is the *Periplus of the Ery threan Sea,* written between A.D. 40 and 75, the work of an anonymous sailor who had actually made the voyage from Rome to the ports of western India. [4] The *Periplus* sailor's handbook lists commodities worth exporting to and bringing back from India and is also a definitive guide for sailing to and from India's western or Malabar Coast, with extensive descriptions of the harbors and ports encountered on the way. The *Natu ral History* of Pliny the Elder (A.D. 23–79), primarily a scientific treatise, provides useful details on Indian ports and most notably makes an exaggerated claim that there was a serious drain of Rome's precious metals to India to pay for the luxury trade. [5] Works by the Egyptian Claudius Ptolemaeus (Ptolemy, A.D. 100–170) offer a comprehensive list of ports and inland centers of second-century India. [6] Of particular interest is his reference to one emporium and one royal residence per Indian maritime district. When compared to first-century works, Ptolemy's compilation shows a growing knowledge of the trade routes and documents the expansion of trade into new regions. Especially noteworthy is his knowledge of the Coromandel or eastern coast of India, of which nothing is said in the *Periplus.*

Roman trade interest focused on two commodities that India offered: Malabar pepper and cloth, both Indian and Chinese. Pliny eloquently described Roman demand for Indian pepper:



> It is quite surprising that the use of pepper has come so much in fashion, seeing that, in other substances which we use, it is sometimes their sweetness and sometimes their appearance that has attracted our notice; whereas, pepper has nothing in it that can plead as a recommendation to either fruit or berry, its only desirable quality being a certain pungency; and yet it is for this that we import it all the way from India! Who was the first to make trial of it as an article of food? And who, I wonder, was the man that was not content to prepare himself by hunger only for the satisfaction of a greedy appetite? [7]

Prior to the first century, the coast-hopping trade made northern Indian ports the most expedient destination for Western vessels. Spices from Malabar were carried north by Indian coastal fleets where they were exchanged for commodities from the West. According to the *Periplus,* Barygaza in present-day Gujarat was the most important destination of the coastal galleys. The overland caravan route between India and China also terminated in Barygaza in that period, further heightening this port's significance as an international center of trade. Finished Chinese silk cloth carried overland through Central Asia was transported down from Taxila in the north, partly via a highway built several centuries before, where it was exchanged for Arabian frankincense, "a product always more highly valued in China than India." [8] Another route was used for the transport of Chinese silk threads from Taxila south to Barbaricum at the mouth of the Indus River. From there the yarn was carried by sea to Arabia, where it was used in the manufacture of embroidered and silk-shot fabrics. This route down the Indus is described in the *Peri plus* as less important "owing to the character of the tribes living on the lower reaches [of the river]," reminding readers that political instability in a port area was a serious impediment to commercial development. [9]

Pliny detailed the change in this pattern. Of primary importance was the discovery of the monsoons, known in Rome as the *Hippalos* winds, which made possible direct travel first between Arabia and the Indus River ports; later a shorter route in both distance and time from Arabia to Kalligeris, south of present-day Bombay, was developed. In the first century A.D. yet shorter direct voyages were made to the Malabar ports themselves. It is believed that the monsoon winds were known in the West before Roman expansion but that they were a well-kept secret of Arab (Parthian) commercial middlemen and their Indian trade agents. [10] For this reason, the profitable spice trade was until then exclusively in the hands of Arab merchants. The *Periplus* attributes the discovery of the monsoons to the Roman sailor Hippalos, thus the common Roman reference to the *Hippalos* winds, and informs us that in the time of the *Peri plus*' author Roman ships began crossing from North Africa to southern Malabar Coast ports. With knowledge of the monsoon winds there came a change in ship construction. Multi-oared galleys were replaced by sailing ships, and a new rigging system, perhaps a Persian innovation, allowed ships to sail closer to the wind.

The Western termini of Roman ships were the Red Sea ports of Myos Hormos and Berenice, from which Indian goods were transported overland by caravan to the Nile and then by boat to Alexandria (see map 2). [11] Apparently to break the Arab monopoly on the India trade and ensure its control of ports with access to the Indian Ocean, Rome began to exert its authority over the Red Sea region during the first century. The *Periplus* reports that a Roman military garrison was established at Leuke Kome, a small-vessel port at the mouth of the Red Sea populated by Arab seamen, to collect a duty of 25 percent of all imports. Meanwhile trade at the “official” Roman ports in the Red Sea was being charged only a 3 percent duty. [12] It may be logically concluded from this account that the Roman government was forcing the India trade merchants to patronize Rome’s “preferred” ports and not those of the Arab merchants. This action was quite similar to practices the Romans had observed in India during the same period.

There appear to have been treaty relationships between Roman merchants and the Indian ports. The *Periplus* uses the phrase *nomimom emporium* (“lawful market”) with respect to Kalligeris. [13] Ptolemy singles out sixteen coastal towns as emporia from the Indus to the Ganges (e.g., Muziris emporium, Podouke emporium), which apparently were the principal commercial centers of each maritime district, each having been assigned special legal provisions for trading. The *Periplus* states that local markets on the west coast between Barygaza and Malabar could be visited only under the supervision of the rulers of the area. [14] At Kalligeris, the rulers had cancelled, or at least obstructed, rights conferred on traders by their predecessors to the extent of seizing Greek ships upon arrival. Guards were placed on board an offending ship, which was then taken to the “official” port at Barygaza.

Various Western literary sources imply that an international port in order to be successful in these times had to offer a neutral meeting ground for a cosmopolitan population. It was not enough for a port to offer goods from its own hinterland or from regions farther afield. The international merchant groups active in the port region had to feel a sense of security, but the “protection” provided had to be carefully regulated so that the visiting merchants did not feel threatened or abused. If an inland-based political power put too many restraints on the traders they would have shifted their operations to another port that allowed them more freedom to transact their business.

The *Arthaśāstra,* the classical north Indian treatise on statecraft, describes in general terms the trade transacted in the international markets found on the coasts during these times and makes a distinction between commerce conducted in the fortified cities of the interior and that taking place in those designated centers for international exchange known as *pattana.* [15] *Pattana* markets were administered by three royal officials. Market exchange was coordinated by a “supervisor of markets,” whose chief function, according to the *Arthaśāstra,* was to keep merchants and artisans from cheating their customers. When commodities of distant origin came into the marketplace the supervisor of markets called in the “director of trade,” an expert in determining prices, who then fixed a price on the foreign commodities after calculating the investment, production, duty, interest, rent, and other expenses that contributed to the fair price of such items. This director of trade was normally subordinate to a “commissioner of ports,” whose duty it was to set regulations for the port town. In the terminology of the *Arthaśāstra,* a *pat tana* was an emporium, a place officially designated by local rulers as a legal center for the exchange of goods that arrived by boat or caravan.

The formal international trade agreements concerning emporia were subject to continuous negotiation. Access to Indian markets by foreign merchants had to be arranged with local authorities before the merchants were allowed to participate in local commerce. The reverse might also be true, that is, that ports sought out the merchants for trade, since embassies negotiating such treaties were to be found moving from East to West. Two Indian delegations to Augustus Caesar were recorded in 25 B.C. and 21 B.C., which coincides with the entry of Roman traders into the Indian markets and the circumvention of Arab sailors and other intermediaries who had monopolized the India traffic prior to that time. [16]

We know from the *Periplus* that Barygaza was India’s greatest port during the first century chiefly because of its cloth trade and as a result had become the principal point of contact between the Western and Eastern commercial realms. Most of Barygaza’s exports were sent there from other commercial centers and included onyx-stones, porcelain, cottons, silk cloth, and peppers. Barygaza’s imports from Roman ports were wines from the Italian peninsula, brass, copper, tin, lead, coral, cloth goods, white glass from Arabia, gold and silver specie (“which brings a profit when exchanged for native specie”), [17] perfumes, and a steady supply of luxuries for the local king. The commercial dominance of Barygaza over other hinterland and coastal centers on the subcontinent is emphasized in the *Periplus.* Local ports such as Suppara (Sopara) and Kalligeris were said to be subservient to Barygaza. But the *Periplus* also notes the emergence of Nelkunda and Muziris (Cochin) on the Malabar Coast as ports of trade outside Barygaza’s sphere of influence. These were the ports where Roman vessels could acquire pepper without dealing through Barygaza middlemen.

Rome's discovery of the monsoons was critical to the emergence of south Indian ports as independent centers of trade, free from Barygaza's economic dominance. The Malabar Coast pepper supply was sufficient to attract Western ships, and once direct trade with the West was established these ports became dominant over their own commercial network. Chinese silk and goods that had been transported overland to the Malabar Coast from the southeastern regions of the subcontinent—pearls, ivory, cloth goods, and jewels—were also available to Roman ships anchoring in south Indian ports. In exchange Roman ships traded great quantities of specie, cloth, white glass, copper, brass, tin, lead, and wine—essentially the same commodities that they traded at Barygaza. [18]

The author of the *Periplus* had nothing to say of India's eastern coast and beyond. Ptolemy was the first knowledgeable authority in the Roman realm on the geography of India's Coromandel Coast, and it appears that his information was largely new to his readers. [19] Classical Tamil literature from south India describes the emporium of Kaverippumppattinam, an east coast terminus for both overland and coastal trade in the first centuries of the Christian era. Kaverippumppattinam had a huge warehouse to which were taken large quantities of articles obtained from numerous places. [20] The excavations at Arikamedu substantiate this literary reference. The distribution and concentration of Roman coin hoards across the southern part of the subcontinent indicate that an overland route was preferred during the first century, with caravans of merchants crossing from the Malabar Coast to the Kaveri River. The traders of the Roman Orient left circumnavigation of the subcontinent to Indian merchants and their smaller vessels. [21] Whether these commercial centers were reached by land or by sea, however, it is clear that they were part of the developing India-Rome trade network by the mid-first century.

The study of Roman coin hoards found in India further substantiates these contacts. Of sixty-eight coinage finds throughout the entire subcontinent, no fewer than fifty-seven were discovered in the south, and of these fifty-seven all but a few stray Roman coins were found in hoards located inland between the western and eastern coasts. These are invariably of gold or silver content; coins of Augustus (27 B.C.–A.D. 14) and Tiberius (A.D. 14–37) predominate. [22]

According to the *Periplus,* first in importance among first-century imports carried by Western merchants to the Malabar Coast ports were gold and silver coins. Pliny noted that India absorbed some 55 million gold coins *(sesterces)* annually, and further stated that 100 million *ses terces* were taken to India, China, and Arabia combined. [23] It is interesting that most recovered Roman coins have been either pierced for suspension or mutilated by a cut across their obverse, which implies that Indians used this coinage as bullion rather than as currency. Roman coins, it seems, were weighed out in exchange for goods, a fact that explains the existence of the south Indian hoards. As subdivided and stamped subunits of precious metal, coins undoubtedly facilitated the Indian trader's accounting and also benefited him in his dealings with his customers; that they were widely recognized units of value no doubt made it easier for the trader to negotiate his various transactions with numerous population centers that would have had no other common unit of exchange.

The flowering of Roman trade in the Indian Ocean during the first century A.D. not only had important implications for Rome but was also of significance to the development of political and economic centers in southern India. Recent scholarship views this commercial growth as a critical stimulus to the evolution of south Indian statecraft. Former tribal chiefs are seen seizing the opportunities offered by the growing trade to organize the flow of trade goods out of the hinterland and into the coastal ports, expanding their political hegemony in the process. [24] This thesis may well be valid, for it is during this era that the earliest south Indian states begin to appear. Corresponding to this political development and in response to the demand for local commodities, new hinterland commercial and political centers evolved. It is no coincidence that the most illustrious hinterland urban center of that time, the Pāṇḍya capital of Madurai, was strategically located at the center of a major cotton producing and weaving region and was as well directly linked to the major caravan route between the western and eastern coasts of southern India. [25]

INITIAL MARITIME CONTACTS WITH SOUTHEAST ASIA

Early references to trade with Southeast Asia are rather ambiguous. Indian literature from the first centuries A.D. refers to Southeast Asia in general as Yāvadvīpa or Suvarṇadvīpa, the "Golden Island" or "Golden Peninsula." The *Rāmāyaṇa,* India's great classical-era epic poem about Rama's attempts to rescue his wife, who had been abducted by the king of Sri Lanka, records seven kingdoms on the "Gold and Silver Islands" beyond Sri Lanka. The Buddhist *Jātaka* fables from popular literature mention Indian merchants who went to Southeast Asia in search of wealth. Ptolemy, writing in the mid-second century, uses Yāvadvīpa, "the Golden Peninsula," in describing the lands beyond India. He makes it quite clear that few Roman sailors were making the passage to Yāvadvīpa, and indeed Indian evidence indicates that not many Indian sailors were making the passage either.

Chinese records provide a more satisfactory yet still incomplete view of the burgeoning Southeast Asian commerce. Substantial references to Western trade began to appear in official Han sources in the last decade of the first century. By 111 B.C., the Han dynasty had extended its control into southern China, and Han emperors, following the lead of the illustrious emperor Han Wu-ti (140–87 B.C.), who is believed to have encouraged the development of the Central Asian caravan route, came into control of Canton, a coastal city with strong commercial interests. During a break in Han rule in A.D. 9–25, the southern part of China had become a haven for refugees escaping from the turmoil in the north, among them northern aristocrats, who further encouraged the development of Canton as a commercial center. These aristocrats, now resident in the south, constituted a growing market for Western goods.

The term *Ta-ch'in* was used by the Chinese to refer to the Roman provinces in the Middle East stretching from Syria to Egypt. From these western regions "precious and rare objects of all foreign countries" were said to come. [26] A Han history text dating from A.D. 125 vaguely describes Ta-ch'in's trade with the northwestern coast of India. Profit to Ta-ch'in's traders from this trade was said to be tenfold, but "honest." [27] Ta-ch'in products reaching China included glass, carpets, rugs, embroideries, piece goods, and precious stones. Among these, manufactured goods—notably glassware in the form of imitation jewelry and ornaments of colored glass—were especially valued. [28]

There are several reasons for the growth of maritime trade during the first century. First, historians have theorized that gold became difficult to acquire during this time. [29] Due to internal disturbances in the Central Asian steppe region, caravan routes from Central Asia no longer provided gold from Siberian deposits, one of the major sources of the precious metal in the Asian world in earliest times. Since gold was the medium of Asian trade, enabling commercial exchanges between merchants of disparate cultures, new sources had to be found to cover trade imbalances. The demand for Roman gold coinage increased accordingly until the emperor Nero (A.D. 54–68) responded to inflation by debasing the gold content in Roman coinage, which quickly brought decreasing interest among Eastern traders in accepting Rome's coins in commercial transactions.[30] The emperor Vespasian (A.D. 69–79) made an official attempt to stop the unfavorable flow of gold coins away from Rome.[31] As a consequence, Indian merchants began looking toward the mythical wealth of the "Islands of Gold" with keen interest and embarked on a major effort to secure these riches.

Second, the quest for gold coincided with the revolution in boat construction and navigation techniques. By the first century Western ships were being built with fore and aft rigging that greatly increased sailing efficiency. Ships of considerable size came into use, some with the capacity to carry six to seven hundred tons of cargo. Pliny wrote of a 75-ton ship making the ocean crossing.

Third, the first century marked a great age of Buddhism in South Asia. Buddhism did not view commercial activity as negatively as did the Hindu tradition. Its spread during this time was tied to the evolution of the new Mahāyāna Buddhist school in northern India. Under the patronage of rich Indian merchants, Buddhist monks who instructed the lay community split with the monks of the Theravāda school, who observed the more elitist "Way of the Fathers." The popular worship of the Mahāyāna sect was practiced in great public shrines rather than in the seclusion of monasteries. Less scholastic and not as concerned with self-attainment, Mahāyāna developed the concept of compassion and of assisting others to salvation as symbolized by the Bodhisattva, the "Buddha-to-Be" who postponed his own ultimate salvation to remain among mortals as a spiritual guide. The Mahāyāna school can be viewed as a response to a dynamic and expanding world, a world intimately connected to commerce. Buddhist tales (*Jātakas*) thus came to deal extensively with the activities of common men, including their economic activities, normally ignored in Hindu literature. In these tales the pursuit of wealth, as long as it was not accomplished at the expense of others, was not seen as evil but was considered natural to man. Indian Ocean seamen were particularly devoted to the Buddha Dīpamkara, the "Calmer of the Waters."[32] Significantly, a number of outstanding Dīpamkara statues associated with this era are distributed throughout the Southeast Asian archipelago. [33]

By the sixth century Buddhism would become especially important to the Chinese, and Southeast Asia played a key intermediary role between South Asia, the source of Buddhism, and China. Buddhist monks passed along the international sea route and by a land route through Burma; Chinese monks traveled to India to acquire deeper understanding of their faith; and Indian monks journeyed to China to share their knowledge with Chinese patrons. As early as the third century an urban community on the edge of the Red River Delta in Vietnam had become a center of Buddhism, with at least twenty temples and over five hundred monks in residence. By the seventh-century voyage of the Chinese pilgrim I-ching, it was viewed as an important stopping point prior to one's entry into China, not only because it was a commercial entrepôt but also because it had become an important religious center for Buddhist pilgrims. [34]

The Sumatran state of Śrīvijaya was also in that age considered a "must" stop for pilgrims. Śrīvijaya, like Vietnam, seems to have been able to fit into the more egalitarian Buddhist world order. I-ching reported that an international community of a thousand monks studied at the capital of the Śrīvijaya monarch in 671. Those who traded with the Chinese and Indian markets in the name of the Śrīvijaya ruler could claim prestige appropriate to those who came into contact with this great patron of the Mahāyāna Buddhist school. Mahāyāna Buddhism thereby allowed Southeast Asian realms that followed the Vietnam and Śrīvijaya examples prestige in the channels of religious communication, raising their status above the "barbarian" image normally held by the Chinese of Southeast Asians and providing the basis for intellectual as well as commercial interaction among the states that participated in the international maritime route.

A fourth reason for the growth of maritime trade through Southeast Asia was Chinese interest, which broadened after the disintegration of the Han dynasty between A.D. 190 and 225. With trouble in Central Asia along the old caravan route and political strife in northern China, there was an increasing need for a southern maritime link between East and West.

Western diplomatic missions to China traveled overland until A.D. 160, when suddenly missions from northern India began to arrive by sea reflecting Central Asian upheaval that must have effectively closed the overland route. The south

China based Wu dynasty (A.D. 220–264) encouraged the import of Western textiles (mainly Indian cotton), tree resins, coral, pearls, amber, glassware, jewelry, and other manufactures. A group of traders appeared on the south China coast in A.D. 166 claiming to be envoys from the Roman emperor Marcus Aurelius Antoninus; in 226, Ta-ch'in merchants from the West visited the Wu court. They were questioned extensively by the emperor Sun Ch'uan himself, who sent an official to accompany them on their return voyage. [35] Lu Tai, Wu governor of a Chinese province in northern Vietnam, was assigned a special role in advertising south China's interest in this trade, sending envoys "to the South." When envoys from the lower Vietnam coastal states of Funan and Lin-yi paid official visits in 226 and 231, respectively, Lu Tai was congratulated by the emperor for his "meritorious performance." In 240, Wu envoys were dispatched to Funan's ports to view firsthand the nature of trade with the West—and seemingly as well to evaluate whether conquest down the coast beyond the Red River Delta would be worthwhile. [36] These envoys' reports not only provided important information on Funan but also on Ta-ch'in and northern Indian commercial centers.

K'ang T'ai, one of the envoys, informed his emperor that the kingdom of Funan was a prosperous realm from which great merchant ships departed for China and India. Funan's authority stretched beyond the lower Mekong Delta to the upper Malay Peninsula. After a major naval expedition in the early third century, Funan had assumed authority over many of the trade centers on the Malay coast, thereby consolidating its dominance over the flow of commerce through Southeast Asia. By the early fourth century, however, significant changes were taking place on the international route that resulted in the demise of Funan and other northern peninsula commercial centers.

THE FIFTH-CENTURY TRANSITION

In the second half of the fourth century the Chin dynasty in China lost access to the Central Asian caravan routes. While in the third century the south China-based Wu elite had depended totally on the maritime route for luxury goods from the West, the Chin elite had been able to balance their needs, receiving goods from both the maritime and overland networks. However, with the loss of access to the caravan route they too began to encourage the further development of the sea passage. Of greatest consequence to Funan was the reaction of would-be Southeast Asian entrepôts south and east of the Malay Peninsula to the new commercial initiatives by the Chinese. Chinese efforts to expand the volume of trade along the sea route had met with an immediate response from a number of Sunda Strait coastal centers that had already been trading directly with India but indirectly with China via Funan's ports. These commercial rivals quickly seized the opportunity to trade directly with China.

Records of direct commercial and maritime contact between the Java Sea region and China show that by the fifth century Funan's role as the principal commercial power in the Southeast Asian world was being seriously eroded. In 430, the ruler of the western Java kingdom known to the Chinese as Ho-lo-tan/t'o petitioned the Chinese court seeking protection for his ships that sailed on a regular basis to China.[37] The significance of this embassy is that it documents the fact that direct voyages were being made from the Sunda Strait region to China across the South China Sea, bypassing Funan.

The Sunda Strait state known to the Chinese as Ko-ying was described in sixth-century Chinese records as having been previously cut off from China. "For generations" Ko-ying had traded with China via Funan. Nevertheless, Ko-ying had evolved during the Funan era as a terminus for shipping using the Strait of Malacca, a point of departure for trade between India and the Spice Islands of the eastern archipelago.[38] At Koying's trade depots Indian merchants acquired the forest products and spices of the archipelago in exchange for pearls, gold, jade, areca nuts, glassware, and horses. In the fifth century, however, Ko-ying's economic position was challenged by the western Java commercial center of Ho-lo-tan/t'o, and ultimately both were replaced by a new southeast Sumatra commercial center, Kan-t'o-li, and its successor, the Śrīvijaya state, as the dominant maritime power in the western Java Sea realm.

Evidence that Funan was being bypassed in favor of a Strait of Malacca and South China Sea passage comes first from the Buddhist pilgrim Fa Hsien. Fa Hsien had traveled from China to India overland but returned by sea from Sri Lanka in A.D. 413–414. His description of the return voyage provides a vivid picture of the sea passage from Sri Lanka to Southeast Asia:

> [I] took passage on board a large merchant vessel, on which there were over two hundred souls, and astern of which there was a smaller vessel in tow in case of accidents at sea and destruction of

> the big vessel. Catching a fair wind [i.e., the monsoon], [we] sailed eastwards for two days; then [we] encountered a heavy gale, and the vessel sprang a leak. The merchants wished to get aboard the smaller vessel; but the men on the latter, fearing that they would be swamped by numbers, quickly cut the tow-rope in two. The merchants were terrified, for death was close at hand; and fearing that the vessel would fill, they promptly took what bulky goods there were and threw them into the sea.... The gale blew on for thirteen days and nights, when [we] arrived alongside an island, and then, at ebb-tide, they saw the place where the vessel leaked and forthwith stopped it up, after which [we] again proceeded on [our] way. This sea is infested with pirates, to meet whom is death. The expanse is boundless.... [39]

After sailing through the Strait of Malacca, Fa Hsien landed at a trade depot known to the Chinese as Yeh-p'o-t'i, believed to have been located on the west coast of Borneo. From there he might have been expected to go to Funan, for archaeological evidence from the presumed site of Yeh-p'o-t'i, notably carved sacrificial posts known as *yūpas,* substantiate a Borneo cultural link to Funan, indicating as with other archipelago coastal centers that early interactions between these depots and the Chinese and Indian commercial markets had been funneled through Funan's ports. [40] Yet Fa Hsien went directly from Yeh-p'o-t'i to Canton, a voyage of fifty days under normal conditions.

An Indian prince and Buddhist monk, Guṇavarman, also sailed from India to Southeast Asia in the early fifth century, landing at the Javanese trade depot of She-p'o. He departed from there with the intention of making an intermediate stop in a Lin-yi (Cham) port on the lower Vietnam coast before entering China. The winds were unfavorable, however, and the merchant ship on which he had taken passage sailed nonstop for China. [41]

Indigenous elites in early Southeast Asian coastal centers found that the increased volume of international trade during this era afforded them with other opportunities as well. Local leaders came to recognize that facilitating trade could be useful in reinforcing their sovereignty vis-à-vis potential rivals and subordinates. Successful rulers could organize the flow of local products from their hinterlands to their courts, sell the products themselves or receive a share of the profits from others' sales, and assess fees on international merchants who came to trade for the products in their ports. Income from this trade amounted to a significant supplement to the income a landed or tribal elite already received from lands they held. Exotic goods and additional income from trade also enhanced an elite's capacity to implement their gift-giving "ritual sovereignty" (discussed later in this chapter), thereby increasing their alliance capital. Southeast Asian rulers thus found it in their personal interest to control local contact with the international trade routes. Rulers consequently took great interest in the collection and redistribution of wealth derived from trade. This wealth, as well as foreign luxury goods acquired on the coast, was shared with supporters to reinforce the status of the monarch and his subordinate elite. The development of new state systems was thus in part due to an elite's successful manipulation of external and indigenous commercial networks to expand their authority vis-à-vis competing elites.

As noted in chapter 1, by the fifth century the southern coast of Sumatra had become a "favored coast," serving the archipelago as well as hinterland systems that had formerly been within the Funan sphere of influence. The new importance of this favored coast was partially due to the expanding Chinese market for Southeast Asian products. Chinese overtures encouraged river-mouth centers in the Java Sea region to send their products directly to Chinese ports. Chinese initiatives also stimulated competition among the emerging trade depots for dominance over neighboring river-mouth centers.

Commercial centers on the Sumatran coast near the Sunda Strait enjoyed a strategic location between the riches of the Java Sea region and China. Their coastal and hinterland networks were easily mobilized to provide manpower and goods for the China trade. Malay ships and crews transported Sumatran products and Java Sea spices to China and brought back Chinese goods. Soon coastal rulers began to use these same seamen to police the Strait of Malacca, for piracy was a plague to shipping in this area. Once it was brought under control, maritime contacts between Sumatran ports and India expanded. Ships from India began sailing south through the strait instead of landing on the upper Malay Peninsula and sending their goods by land across the Isthmus of Kra. Trade depots vied for political supremacy over rival river-mouth centers on the coasts of southeastern Sumatra, northwestern Java, and southwestern Borneo, all the while maintaining and facilitating the movement of goods between Chinese, Indian, and other Southeast Asian markets.

With this transition to the sea passage through the Strait of Malacca, Funan's ports became peripheral to the mainstream of international commerce. To participate in international trade, Funan's traders had to travel to other trade depots, just as previously Southeast Asian seafarers had to come to Funan to carry on their exchanges.

THE CHINA TRADE

Who provided passage from Southeast Asia's ports to China and India in the first centuries of the Christian era? Early Chinese records make it clear that Malay ships and seamen based in Southeast Asia, identified by the term *K'un-lun,* sailed the route between Southeast Asia and China. [42] Until the eleventh century no Chinese ships made the voyage on a regular basis, and until the sixth century Persian ships went no farther east than Sri Lanka. There is disagreement, however, on who provided the passage from South Asia to Southeast Asia.

Many Western historians initially thought that Indian seamen in Indian-made ships developed the route. In reiterating this view, one has recently argued that Southeast Asian seamen were not capable of building the great ships making the voyage. [43] Indians duplicated in shipyards along the Indian coast the more advanced Persian ships, and Indian sailors, most of them Buddhists, then sailed the vessels with their international passengers and cargoes to the "Land of Gold." Opposing this position, other historians now believe that it was not Indians but Southeast Asians piloting K'un-lun ships from the Southeast Asian archipelago to India and back who provided this early linkage for international merchants, [44] which would make Southeast Asian seamen responsible for opening the entire sea route from India to China. They point to Western accounts from this age that record voyages by Malay seafarers as far west as the African coast and draw the conclusion that if Malay ships could reach Africa, they could reach India.

When the need for a maritime route increased, these seamen were able to turn their maritime skills to financial gain. Because Western traders at this time were primarily interested in exchanging Western goods for Chinese products, access to the ports of south China was a critical factor that allowed Malay seamen to expand their Western trade. By securing Chinese commodities and transporting them to Southeast Asian and South Asian trade depots, Southeast Asian seamen eliminated the need for Western ships to venture beyond South Asia.

Malay seamen, however, were not only facilitators of international trade; they could be a serious obstacle as well. They had the potential to be shippers or pirates. Chinese records report that "merchant ships of the barbarians" (K'un-lun) were used to transfer Chinese envoys to their destinations in the archipelago, and that these seamen profited equally from the trade and from plundering and killing people. [45] Herein the Malay seamen's duality is fully recognized. The Chinese considered Southeast Asia to be generally unstable politically and a potential threat to the efficient flow of commercial goods into China. The Chinese government in its dealings with Southeast Asian states was not as much interested in having its political legitimacy and dominance recognized—there was no need to annex the southern regions since the Chinese ruling elite was sure that the southern barbarians would eventually become part of the Chinese cultural realm—as it was in establishing commercial goals as the basis of relationships. The Chinese thus looked for a strong, dominant state in the area that would be able to maintain trade and prevent plundering by the sea pirates based in Southeast Asian waters.

The Chinese apparently favored consistency, preferring not to shift alliances from one state to another. They would recognize one state and attempt to maintain a tributary relationship with it. If the state stopped sending envoys to the Chinese court the Chinese would try to reestablish contact with the state before granting official recognition to another. Southeast Asian states in a tributary relationship with China received nothing from the Chinese but recognition of their legitimacy and trading status. Appeals for direct military aid or patronage were generally ignored. [46] Southeast Asian states did capitalize on Chinese recognition, however, to attract trade to their ports. Chinese support bestowed on them a legitimacy that contributed to their rise. Traders who frequented a "legitimate" coastal trading center seem to have been given preferential treatment in their trade with China, The Malay seamen who provided shipping for goods and merchants saw the potential for acquiring great wealth in the China trade and joined forces with the legitimized states. They turned to policing rather than pirating the sea channels and in return for their loyalty shared in the trade-derived prosperity.

So critical was Chinese recognition that any coastal trade depot wishing to prosper sent a tribute mission to the Chinese court. According to one historian's analysis of these political missions, which were dutifully recorded by Chinese scribes, when they were few it meant stability in the area, that is, when one trade depot's authority over the sea lanes was unchallenged. [47] Periods of internal dissension and political turmoil are reflected, on the other hand, by numerous tribute missions, as various coastal commercial centers competed for the preferred status the Chinese could bestow. For example, in the era of Funan's supremacy, Funan ports were officially recognized by the Chinese court and sent few tribute missions. But by the fifth century, when the pattern of trade was shifting from Funan to the Sunda Strait region, numerous tribute missions from the former economic subordinates of Funan appeared at the Chinese court soliciting favorable trade relationships. Funan attempted to regain Chinese favor, sending both tributary missions and trade envoys to the Chinese court, but the Chinese, fully aware of the transition taking place in trading patterns, chose to ignore the Funan initiative and to give official recognition instead to the ports of a southeastern Sumatra state as well as to those of Funan's neighbor, former vassal, and mortal enemy, the Cham state of Lin-yi.

THE IMPACT OF TRADE ON STATE DEVELOPMENT IN SOUTH INDIA AND SOUTHEAST ASIA

Over the years historians have examined the possible roles of Brahman priests, Kṣatriya warrior-adventurers, or Vaiśya traders from India in spreading Indian civilization along the emerging maritime routes to developing Southeast Asian states. While some have postulated wholesale colonization by Indian exiles, [48] others have maintained that "Indianization" was wholly created by Southeast Asians themselves, by summoning Brahmans to their courts and creating a thin veneer of Indianized customs. [49] Indeed, the historical records provide no evidence of Indian colonies, Indian conquest, or direct Indian control. The adoption of Indic culture appears to have been voluntary on the part of the Southeast Asians, although some segments of a Southeast Asian society may well have had Indian cultural forms imposed upon them by an indigenous elite. Since the process did not merely occur once or twice but on numerous occasions between the third and fourteenth centuries A.D., in riverine coastal centers as well as in hinterland wet-rice plains, questions of who brought the Indian civilization are better refocused to ask how and why Southeast Asians chose to adopt the Indic culture. [50]

In response to these questions of how and why, a comparative examination of expanding international commercial contacts in southern India and Southeast Asia may provide a basis for understanding transitions in Indian Ocean commercial patterns and also contribute to an understanding of early south Indian and Southeast Asian political organization. South India is different from northern India historically and ethnically: the relationship of south India to northern India is in some ways parallel to the relationship of Southeast Asia to northern India—the differences are differences of degree. The historical issues confronting the scholar of early Southeast Asian civilization are similar to those raised by southern Indian civilization. Both areas developed state systems by integrating north Indian Sanskritic ideology with existing cultural forms. Thus by coming to terms with the process of state formation in southern India, whose history is far better documented than that of early Southeast Asia, one may acquire a conceptual perspective that can be tested and applied on a comparative basis to Southeast Asia; that is, the understanding of one in many ways facilitates the better understanding of the other.

The study of south Indian history suggests that while early south Indian monarchs were in general introspective, their interest in promoting trade and in the development of institutions and organizations to enable the efficient flow of products into and out of their ports was stimulated by the potential revenue to be gained from cesses on luxury goods brought in by seafaring merchants. Between the sixth and fourteenth centuries—the height of classical Southeast Asian civilization and also the golden age of early south Indian civilization—the Coromandel Coast was under the rule of the Pallava and Cōḻa dynasties. Their royal style required the conspicuous display of grandeur; seeing the benefits to be derived from a positive attitude toward commerce, these rulers structured their relationships accordingly with those who participated in the trade. [51]

In Pallava and Cōḻa times agricultural settlements were spreading inland from the coast along river valleys. [52] Clusters of villages inhabited by a settled agrarian population were surrounded by various nonagrarian areas occupied by tribal peoples. The village clusters were dominated by a local landholding elite. In this multicentered system of power, direct control by a royal house extended only to the village clusters located near the base of royal power. Beyond the royal centers dynastic rulers were limited in their ability to mobilize material and human resources.

A village cluster tried to preserve local resources for its own use, which created tensions between local and higher levels of political authority on the issue of who was to receive what share of the local agricultural surplus. A strong community was able to retard the flow of goods to a political center. The dynastic rulers sometimes found it necessary to undertake military campaigns, not to conquer territory but to take plunder to offset the villagers' unwillingness to share their surplus. [53] Often a ruler's desire for personal glory was at odds with the amount of revenue he could peacefully extract from his own domain. As a result royal armies were frequently turned loose into the field where they sustained themselves on the resources of conquered territories.

As an alternative to the use of force, south Indian kings attempted to institutionalize and regularize their relationships with landholding elites. Particular emphasis was placed on the peaceful consolidation of the population through the royal bestowal of legitimacy on certain local rulers, a theory of legitimacy that drew heavily on Brahmanical Hindu thought. The network of alliances that south Indian kings constructed was acted out in ceremonies of "ritual sovereignty." [54]

Ritual sovereignty stressed the consolidation of the society under the royal ideology of legitimacy. The integration of semi-autonomous agrarian units into a state system centered upon the king, who functioned as the ritual center—a political, cultural, and social reference rather than an all-powerful authority. By endowing temples, temple ceremonies, and settlements of Brahman-dominated villages in strategic locations, [55] a king could be viewed as expressing his concern for social morality and the spiritual welfare of the realm. It added merit to the royal house when the state endowed a temple with land and funded ceremonies to the perpetual memory of the king. The record of such endowments was inscribed for eternity in the stone of the temple walls. Each inscription reflected the kingly style: long Sanskrit and Tamil eulogies composed at the court were included in the prologue of royal inscriptions throughout the realm. Brahmanical terminology, an important element in the claim of royal legitimacy, was grafted onto existing institutions. Local deities were incorporated into "respectable" pantheons. Local temples and pilgrimage centers were patronized by royalty and gained added luster through the association. Religious patronage was intended to raise the king's status in the eyes of the subject population. Royal inscriptions encouraged this recognition, noting the prosperity the king had brought to his domain. Royal eulogies undoubtedly represented an attempt to diminish the visibility of local elites while increasing that of the king, but there was no similar effort by kings to eliminate or disperse the local centers of power.

Locally entrenched agrarian elites had to be willing to recognize royal suzerainty, however. On the one hand, the king with his superior might could physically eliminate or replace local rulers; on the other hand, the king could defend them against local or outside threats. Aside from the threat of force, the most important legitimizing factor in gaining their cooperation was that south Indian kings were patrons of Sanskritic tradition, which provided an ideological justification for the landed elites' claim to hold superior status vis-à-vis other members of the agrarian order. They also allied themselves with south Indian kings in order to draw upon the dynastic rulers' religious networks and symbols, normally concentrated in temples, thereby enhancing their status by being seen as certified patrons of the royal cults.

In return the king received the fealty of the elites and their subordinates. Sometimes this relationship was formalized by the flow of local cesses into the king's treasury. Such cesses were often immediately returned in the form of royal patronage of local temples. In other instances, locally raised troops might fight as loyal followers of a king in a military campaign and in return share in the spoils of victory. The king's spiritual prowess was also enhanced by local support for royal temples. Notables made gifts to the temples, financed holy ritual in the king's name, or subordinated local temples and their cults, which were supervised by the local elite, to those of the central royal temples. [56]

The political synthesis of Sanskritic culture in south India provides a meaningful parallel to that which took place in Southeast Asia. Notably, Hindu and Buddhist Sanskritic culture provided the basis for south Indian as well as Southeast Asian ritual sovereignty. The adoption of Sanskritic culture was encouraged by leaders in both areas because of its potential as a source of political and social cohesion. Sanskritic culture was not imposed through the conquest of south India or Southeast Asia by northern Indians nor was it due to the mass migration of north Indian elites to the south. Sanskritic ideology was adopted because of the advantages it offered to an emerging indigenous agrarian-based elite, who emulated the Hindu model of kingship and order in which in theory the monarch relied on virtue rather than force to extend his sovereignty. South Indian as well as Southeast Asian monarchs who sought alternatives to violence by which to force the landholding elites into submission depended instead upon ritual kingship to integrate their realm. They promoted alliances rather than relying on the threat of physical retribution.

Revenues generated from maritime commerce reinforced alliance networks. They supplemented local revenue collections and were redistributed by successful monarchs to reinforce the ties formed through their ritual sovereignty. The sea trade described earlier was thus a stimulus to state development. Local chiefs in southern India and Southeast Asia developed their coastal ports to serve the needs of the international trading community. In exchange they garnered income from various port cesses. This revenue in turn increased their wealth such that they were able to transform material benefits into political advantage. For instance, a local leader with an income sufficiently higher than that of his fellow chiefs and tribesmen could expand his manpower base by soliciting the support of rival chiefs and/or their followers. This base of support could then be used to protect or provision the port—for example, to police the sea channels against piracy, stabilize the hinterland, guarantee the flow of food for visiting merchants, or assure the delivery of the local products desired by traders. Followers shared in their chief’s success as a facilitator of international trade through direct redistributions of profits. Rulers also cultivated their followers’ loyalty by subscribing to north Indian Sanskritic religious tradition, which reinforced the chief’s spiritual prowess, putting his magic above that of his followers.

Indic cultural forms were indeed important to evolving Southeast Asian states as an ideological base for their expanding sovereignty. In the chapters to come we shall look at how these cultural forms were introduced into and influenced the development of specific states.